

WHAT MADE SUPERHERO CINEMATIC UNIVERSES SUCCESSFUL?

WRITTEN BY A SUPERHERO-ADDICT

Introduction



*“There was an idea. To bring together a group of remarkable people, to see if they could be something more...” — Nick Fury in **The Avengers** (2012)*

As you might've guessed from the title, I love **superheroes**, and I love **superhero movies**! Despite being entirely fictional, the stories of superhumans using their gifts to protect those who can't defend themselves had always compelled me. Within every re-watch, they still teach me core motivational values in situations that I may encounter throughout my life. Personally, I'm more entertained by the crazy fighting spectacles. Can you even blame me?

My love for superheroes eventually led me to learn about **cinematic universes**. In summary, it is a storytelling medium featuring separate stories (from movies and TV shows) that intersect with each other into one central narrative. Don't confuse them with self-contained works that only follow a single linear narrative rather than incorporating divergent plotlines into a single interconnected story.

So when you mix **superheroes** and **cinematic universes**, you get franchises like the **DC Extended Universe (DCU)**, **Sony's Spider-Man Universe (SSU)**, and my instant go-to, the **Marvel Cinematic Universe (MCU)**. But what brought the sudden rise in the cinematic universe hype? What exactly made superhero cinematic universes stand out amongst other Hollywood films? I can pinpoint them down to three main factors regarding **superheroes**, **cinematics**, and **the interconnected universe**:

Superheroes: What makes Superheroes *Special*?

Isn't it obvious, you can't have a **superhero** movie without **superheroes**!

Superheroes were (and still are) popular amongst other comic book contenders. The concept of "good versus evil" with heroes having to deal with new/recurring villains in every weekly run really appealed to a large mass of comic book readers like me. With each new comic run, they offer a new escape from real-world problems (like **jobs** and **TAXES**) that I can get excited about. But what exactly makes superheroes special in your opinion? I believe it comes from how, despite gaining their extraordinary powers, they still retain their core humanity.

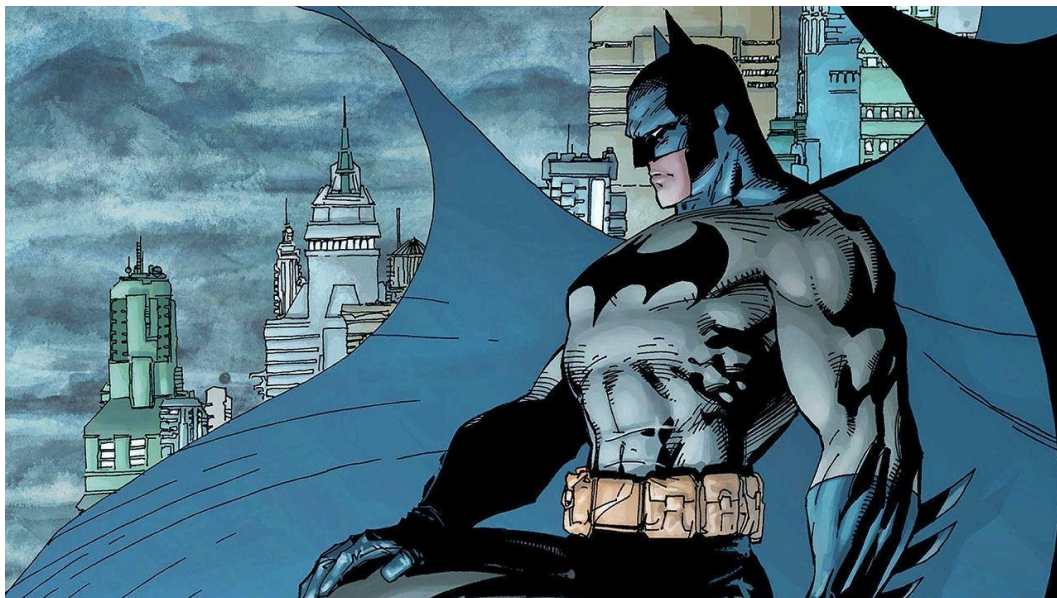
Don't deny it! We have all fantasised about gaining superpowers – who wouldn't?! With powers shown in the comic books, you can easily solve everyday human problems without breaking a single sweat. However, this fantasy does come with its drawbacks. These drawbacks are explored in most notable superhero stories, with our superpowered characters having to come face-to-face with the consequences that come with their hero status. The main problem involves trying to balance/separate their everyday life from their superhero duties, making up a secret superhero identity.

There are thousands of comics that adapted this kind of storyline, featuring characters that are good, evil, and poorly written – most coming from either **Marvel Comics** or **DC Comics**.



Spider-Man swinging through the city in The Amazing Spider-Man (2018 – 2022) by Patrick Gleason

For example, **Spider-Man** (Peter Parker) juggles both his human and superhero responsibilities as if he were in a constant circus act. If he focuses only on one aspect of his life, the other bursts into disaster. Despite contemplating hanging up the costume on multiple occasions, he continued being Spider-Man. His main reason for his decision derives from the death of his uncle and his parting words, "with great power comes great responsibility" – meaning people with such power should be obligated to use that power for the good of others rather than themselves.



Batman (Bruce Wayne), looking down at Gotham menacingly

Even as a billionaire (something we can never achieve), I would say that Batman (Bruce Wayne) is just as flawed and humane, like us. After witnessing his parents' murder, we follow the character as he deals with his PTSD and see how it severely impacts him (via his violent

tendencies, unhappy mood, antisocial behaviour, etc.). He would later have some personal growth and learn/improve on his mistakes, especially by having Robin and the Bat-family aid him in his efforts. Even with his various gadgets, strategic thinking, versatile fighting style, and hella cash, his stories clearly show that he still suffers with the same issues us normal humans would, and yet, is still determined to not back down against his villain entourage, superpowered or not. And that is what makes him **vengeance, the night, Batman**.

Cinematic: The **Wonders** of Superhero Adaptation Films

The idea of seeing your favourite superheroes on the big screen, either in live action or animation, has really brought more comic books into mainstream media. The translation from a select comic book's static imagery into moving pictures provides a new visual spectacle for audiences to witness fights, interactions, and the adapted story in real time in a cinema. Most popular superhero films come from either **Marvel Studios** or **DC Studios**.



Spider-Man (Miles Morales) in Across the Spider-Verse (2023)

Even though we all have our preferences, can we appreciate how beneficial both live action and animation are to adapting its source material? With live action adaptations allowing a more grounded and realistic take on superheroes, and animated adaptations being used to properly showcase fantastical characters and events without looking out of place.

I believe most good movie adaptations became successful due to their respect for the source material and accessibility to be enjoyed by both hardcore and casual viewers. This can be done by having filmmakers and co. who are passionate for the movie adaptation, whilst allowing them to have creative freedom to put their own original twist. There are some superhero film adaptations that don't do this, resulting in their failure.



Line-up shot of the Guardians of the Galaxy in Guardians of the Galaxy Vol 2 (2017)

An example of a good comic book movie adaptation, in my opinion, would be James Gunn's *Guardians of the Galaxy* (2014). Despite the movie differing heavily from its main inspiration (such as Star Lord's mannerisms and costume differing from his comic book appearances), I was still entertained by the director's witty, humorous writing and likeable, memorable characters (despite starting as mercenaries and assassins). The movie also contains unique music choices with songs from the 1900s that make you **feel good** and heroic, and climactic ensembles for great battle scenes (composed by Tyler Bates). Speaking of battle scenes, all of the fights shown always got me so hyped, whether it's in space or on the ground (choreographed by James Young).

Even with all this juicy content, it still has a light-hearted story about finding a newfound family in unusual places, which I can rewatch multiple times and still enjoy. Sorry for the sudden ramble, I just really like this film.

Universe: The **Importance** of Interconnectivity



Nick Fury's cameo appearance in the post-credit scene of Iron Man (2008)

The main factor for the success of a cinematic universe, in my opinion, involves being able to have a rich, expandable main narrative which spans across multiple movie instalments involving numerous storylines, characters, and in-universe events. This can be done by using an interconnected approach when producing movies.

Even though arguably the **Universal Monsters franchise** (1931 – 1955) is the first cinematic universe (by featuring classic horror characters from separate movies crossing over regularly), the **Marvel Cinematic Universe (MCU)**, led by Kevin Feige, would then adopt this concept and become the first successful cinematic universe. The MCU would have 36+ movies and TV series featuring Marvel Comic superheroes intertwined into one huge narrative, which tells a greater story.



The Avengers at the Battle of New York in the Avengers (2012)

MCU's Infinity Saga (Phases 1 – 3) shows this with all their movies leading towards the movie finale, *Avengers: Endgame* (2019) film, including the infinity stones, and later facing Thanos (the main villain). In combination with their meticulously detailed plan, a unique storytelling formula, and Disney's later acquisition of Marvel Entertainment, the MCU soon became a success, grossing [over \\$32.4 billion in revenue](#).

Marvel Studios establishes this interconnective storytelling through common methods sprinkled in their many Marvel film instalments:

Cameos and/or References	Done through conversation, environmental scenery, or literal character appearances in the film
Present engaging character development across films	Progression of a character/group's growth and motivations as a character across multiple films
Post-Credit Scenes	Heavily used in most superhero films. Used to present a preview/early showing of future characters, storylines, and events for the main narrative

DC Studios would later be inspired by the MCU's quick commercial success, and they'd produce their own cinematic universe franchise featuring their DC characters – this was called the **DC Extended Universe (DCEU)**. However, in the overall scheme, despite including fan-favourite characters like Batman, Superman, Wonder Woman, and more, their franchise was classified as a financial bust ([only grossing more than \\$7 billion at the global box office compared to competitors](#)). It needed a soft reboot, changing to the DC Universe (DCU) in 2024, being led by James Gunn and Peter Safran. I believe reasons for this sudden reboot stem from their rushed planning, weak writing choices, and film writers not retaining creative control due to constant studio interference.

The MCU was also heading towards an audience engagement decline during their Multiverse Saga (Phase 4 – 6). I had also stopped engaging as much with Marvel content because of their decision to produce an overabundance of lacklustre content (mainly for the Disney+ service) that lost the exceptional story writing, lack of planning, consistent quality, and interconnected sense of direction. These were initially the MCU's major strengths throughout their Infinity Saga, so this sudden shift really confused me.

Conclusion

In summary, I believe superhero cinematic universe franchises' success stems from having an engaging, expandable storyline which can be interconnected across multiple separate films featuring fan-favourite characters. This form of storytelling allows audiences to indulge in their main narrative while also being able to enjoy the separate movies without requiring knowledge of the fictional universe.

The MCU and other superhero cinematic universes are what got me into superheroes in the first place. For that reason, even if they have been downhill, I will always appreciate them for what they are – a good pastime away from the crushing reality of life. Without discovering superhero movies, I wouldn't have become the "superhero-addict" I am today (even though that is such an overstatement).